

HISTORY HANDBOOK

GUIDELINES FOR UG STUDENTS



ashoka
UNIVERSITY

DEPARTMENT OF HISTORY

ASHOKA UNIVERSITY

The Department of History

The History Department at Ashoka University seeks to equip students with the historian's toolbox and train them on how to use it. A historian combines the skills of a detective, a scavenger, a judge and a ventriloquist. They are an artist and a skilled craftsperson who spin and weave narratives of the past. Historical creativity lies in gathering, wrestling with, and connecting the traces of the past to construct a rich tapestry of human lives, emotions, and ideas. These traces come in various garbs – gravestones, burial sites, forgotten cities, mud pots, musical notes, folklores, war songs, memoirs, archival records, speeches, letters, newspapers, cartoons, cave art, paintings, architecture, clothes, food, chronicles, cinema, advertisements – all and any remnant of human existence.

A historian's ability to make effective use of this material requires inculcation of two core ideas: empathy and imagination. Empathy fuels and glues our connection with other humans. It helps us recognize others' perceptions, feelings and ways of being. Empathy is a vital tool of a historian because it obligates a historian to question and challenge a single conception of the world in order to access other worlds and other lives. Thus, the spirit of questioning and the consciousness of one's own frames of reference is the starting point of historical inquiry. The second feature of imagination is the creative faculty which enables us to form images and feelings that ordinary senses cannot perceive. It is a critical instrument for a historian who studies worlds that are removed both in time and space from his or her own. Conjuring up those historical worlds requires a leap of imagination, a willing suspension of disbelief and a readiness to encounter the unknown.

Why Study History at Ashoka?

- **A flexible curriculum with plenty of choices:** Both the pure and interdisciplinary History Major curricula have only a few mandatory courses. Beyond this, students have the choice to select courses out of a wide range of options depending on their interests. Aside from the gateway course History Matters, the order for taking the other courses is completely flexible. This makes it particularly welcoming for people who decide to join the History Major late.
- **An excellent student-teacher ratio:** Our classes are typically small to medium sized, providing the perfect learning environment and adequate academic attention from the professors, while preventing the myriad learning challenges of large classes. With

an element student-teacher ratio, our classes offer some of the best intellectual discussions and an ideal forum for academic debate and learning.

- **Internship opportunities:** The department and its professors offer an array of internship opportunities ranging from external positions to internal research projects run by individual faculty members that come with their academic and professional mentorship.
- **Inclusive and accommodative degree requirements:** Aside from a wide range of courses offered by the History department, students can also count a number of language courses, cross-listed courses, ISMs, and TA-ship credits towards the four-years degree. This way they gain a rich and well-rounded learning experience.
- **A wide variety in the themes of courses:** Our courses explore different periods of history from prehistory to the modern times. Some focus on India, some on other parts of the world like China, Iran, and West Asia, and yet others offer global historical perspectives. The following sections detail the various types of courses:

A. Mandatory Courses

These courses introduce students to the basics of the discipline of History and the history of South Asia. There are a total of 5 such courses:

- 1) **History Matters** - What is History? This is a course that introduces such basics of the discipline to newcomers. It offers key concepts and immerses students in the rich diversity of different kinds of history. This could be considered as a gateway course for History and is recommended for all students finding out what our discipline is about. For students, it is best done in the first year.
- 2) **History of India I** - This explores a large part of ancient Indian history, especially the time period from prehistory to the Mauryan Empire.
- 3) **History of India II** - This unravels the remaining part of ancient Indian history and a large chunk of the early medieval period, especially the times after the Mauryan Empire till the end of the first millennium CE.
- 4) **History of India III** - This explores the first seven and a half centuries of the second millennium CE, taking students through the early medieval, medieval, and early modern periods.
- 5) **History of India IV** - This investigates the colonial and postcolonial modern periods of South Asian history, covering the period between mid-eighteenth and mid-twentieth centuries.

B. Methods Courses

These courses provide students training in the methodological aspects of reading and writing History. A range of courses are offered along these lines. They are broadly divided into two baskets depending on their level of difficulty and workload. Students are required to choose from the many courses offered in these two baskets.

- 1) **Basic Methods Courses** - These courses are meant for third-year students; others are discouraged, but not prevented, from taking these courses. They introduce students to the basics of the historian's craft while sometimes focusing on specific historical themes.
- 2) **Advanced Methods Courses** - These courses are meant *only* for students of the fourth year. It builds on the previous course and offers more advanced training, especially in reading and writing History.

C. Elective Courses

The Department of History offers a large range of electives on various subjects. Students can choose whatever courses they like from among these. All History electives (as well as ISMs and cross-listed courses from other departments) are divided into three baskets depending on their framing and focus. Students are required to choose from the many courses offered in these three baskets.

- 1) **Global & Comparative History Electives** - These courses explore global histories of specific themes, like war, science, ecology, archaeology, religion, and politics.
- 2) **Non-Indian Region-Focused Electives** - These courses offer in-depth studies of specific world regions beyond South Asia, like Europe, China, Iran, Tibet, West Asia, and Southeast Asia.
- 3) **Indian History Electives** - These courses explore various aspects of the rich history of South Asia, ranging from ancient kingship to colonial science, medieval politics to early modern war, early medieval religion to contemporary culture.

D. Independent Study Modules (ISM)

Students can approach individual professors for courses on specific themes of their interest. These are small classes capped at 5, built around specific topics and centered around students reading texts and discussing their ideas with the professors. For these, the schedules of such discussions are fixed between the students and the professor. All ISMs are included in one of the three baskets of Elective Courses.

E. Language Courses

Languages are keys to the world of knowledge. The university offers courses in several languages like Persian, Chinese, and Sanskrit. The Department of History strongly recommends that its students take some, at least one, of these courses. In the future, the department will explore its options for making more language courses available to its students.

F. Cross-Listed Courses from Other Departments

The department cross-lists a lot of courses from other departments. These stand outside the History course baskets. The department encourages its students to take some of these courses to expand their intellectual horizons.

UG Research at the History Department

Historical research is the blissful world of investigating facets of past societies that follows years of training in the discipline. Students can pursue two kinds of thesis with the Department of History. The first of this is the third-year thesis. This is a semester-long thesis (monsoon semester), which is meant to give students an opportunity to dip their toes in the process of research. This is entirely optional and carries 4 credits; students can take this like they take an elective.

In contrast, the fourth-year thesis comprises 12 credits, split into 4 credits in the monsoon semester and 8 credits in the spring semester. This is a more extensive immersion in research, where students are expected to produce a more serious piece of work after exploring primary sources. This too is optional for fourth-year students. If they want to pursue this thesis, they have to do so over and above the regular fourth-year coursework.

For both the thesis, the planning should start in the previous spring semester. Students should think of a research topic and approach potential faculty supervisors by April. They should gradually concretise the topic in conversation with potential supervisors, read around it, and write a more detailed research proposal through the summer vacation, so that they can formally start their thesis work once the semester begins in August (provided they formally secure the approval of their faculty supervisors).

Pedagogical Apprenticeship

Ashoka University provides a chance to its students to learn the basic ropes of pedagogy by serving as Teaching Practicum Assistants (TPA or simply, TA) to assist professors in conducting courses. TAs manage course logistics, maintain attendance records, mentor students outside the classroom in handling readings and assignments. They cannot grade assignments.

Cap: TA-ships are typically done by fourth-year students. Each TA-ship comprises 2 credits. Fourth-year students can count a maximum of 2 such TA-ships (i.e. a maximum of total 4 credits) towards their History Major degree. Students from other batches can do TA-ships with the approval of the department, but they cannot count these credits towards their Major.

The History Major Degree

The History Major Degree comprises four years of coursework worth 72 credits. Out of these, only 20 credits comprise mandatory courses; students can choose the rest of the courses based on their academic interests and some requirements. The resultant coursework is a rich mix of mandatory and elective courses on Indian history, electives on various historical themes, world regions, and global history, as well as electives that train students in methodological issues. The curriculum consists of the following courses:

5 Mandatory Courses

1. History Matters (4 credits)
2. History of India I (4 credits)
3. History of India II (4 credits)
4. History of India III (4 credits)
5. History of India IV (4 credits)

13 Elective Courses (with the following requirements)

6. Any 1 elective from the Global & Comparative History Electives basket (4 credits)
7. Any 1 elective from the Non-Indian Region-Focussed History basket (4 credits)
8. Any 1 elective from the Basic Methods Courses basket (4 credits)
- 9-10. Any 2 courses from the Advanced Methods Courses basket (8 credits, to be done *only* in the fourth year)

11-18. Any 8 other courses with 4 credits each. These could be electives, language courses, third-year thesis, ISMs, or cross-listed courses (with History) from other departments (4 x 8 credits = a total of 32 credits)

- History Major Degree *with* Research

For the History Major degree *with* the research option, students need to complete a total of 84 credits. Towards this, they have to complete - in addition to the above 72 credits - the Fourth-Year Thesis (12 credits, divided usually as 4 for the monsoon semester and 8 for the spring semester).

CAPS

- A maximum of 3 ISMs (i.e. a total of 12 credits) can count towards the History Major degree in 4 years.
- A maximum of 4 language courses (i.e. total of 16 credits) can count towards the History Major degree in 4 years, with no less than 2 courses in (i.e. a minimum 8 credits) the same language.
- A maximum of 6 courses (i.e. a total of 24 credits) offered by other departments and cross-listed with History can count towards the History Major degree in 4 years.
- Only fourth-year students can count a maximum of 2 TA-ships (i.e. a total of 4 credits) towards their History Major. Till the third year, students cannot count TA-ship credits towards their History Major.

Recommended Order of Courses

One of the main features of the History Major is the flexibility of the curriculum. Students can technically take the mandatory and elective courses in any order. However, the department strongly recommends that students complete the following courses by the end of the third year:

5 Mandatory Courses

1. History Matters (4 credits)
2. History of India I (4 credits)
3. History of India II (4 credits)
4. History of India III (4 credits)
5. History of India IV (4 credits)

8 Elective Courses (with the following requirements)

6. Any 1 elective from the Basic Methods Courses basket (4 credits)
7. Any 1 elective from the Global & Comparative History Electives basket (4 credits)
8. Any 1 elective from the Non-Indian Region-Focussed History basket (4 credits)
- 9 - 13. Any 5 other courses with 4 credits each. These could be electives, language courses, third-year thesis, ISMs, or cross-listed courses (with History) from other departments (20 credits)

In such a scenario, students should be left with the following courses in their fourth year:

- 14-15. Any 2 courses from the Advanced Methods Courses basket (8 credits)
- 16-18. Any 3 other courses. These could be electives, language courses, ISMs, TA-ships, or cross-listed courses (with History) from other departments. (12 credits)

Students taking the History Major *with research* option will ideally be left with the following courses in their fourth year:

- 14-15. Any 2 courses from the Advanced Historical Methods Courses basket (8 credits)
- 16-18. Any 3 other courses. These could be electives, language courses, ISMs, TA-ships or cross-listed courses (with History) from other departments (16 credits)
19. The Fourth-Year Thesis (12 credits, divided usually as 4 for the monsoon semester and 8 for the spring semester)

The History-IR Interdisciplinary Major Degree

This Interdisciplinary Major grounds students strongly in the two disciplines of History and International Relations. It comprises a total of 80 credits (tentatively 20 courses), which are divided equally between the two departments. Consequently, students pursuing this degree are typically required to take 10 courses (each worth 4 credits) with both the History and IR departments. This section details the requirements for the 10 History courses (40 credits).

History Courses (40 credits)

1. History Matters (4 credits)
- 2 & 3. Any 2 courses from the following:
 - History of India I (4 credits)
 - History of India II (4 credits)
 - History of India III (4 credits)
 - History of India IV (4 credits)
4. Any 1 elective from the Global & Comparative History Electives basket (4 credits)
5. Any 1 elective from the Non-Indian Region-Focussed History basket (4 credits)
6. Any 1 elective from the Basic Methods Courses basket (4 credits)
7. Any 1 elective from the Advanced Methods Courses basket (4 credits)
- 8, 9, & 10. Any 3 other courses with 4 credits each. These could be History electives, third-year thesis, ISMs, TA-ships (2 credits each), or cross-listed courses (with History) from other departments (3 x 4 credits = 12 credits).

CAPS

- Students can count a maximum of 2 ISMs (i.e. a total of 8 credits) towards their History-IR Interdisciplinary Major in 4 years.
- A maximum of 2 language courses (i.e. a total of 8 credits) in the same language can count towards the History-IR Interdisciplinary Major degree in 4 years.
- A maximum of 2 courses (i.e. a total of 8 credits) offered by other departments and cross-listed with History can count towards the History-IR Interdisciplinary Major degree in 4 years.
- Only fourth-year students can count a maximum of 2 TA-ships (i.e. a total of 4 credits) towards their History-IR Interdisciplinary Major.

Four-Years Degree with Research

In addition to completing 40 credits in History and another 40 credits in IR, students pursuing the research track are required to write a thesis worth 12 research credits in History or IR, depending on which of these two departments they want to pursue their research in.

- Fourth-Year thesis (4 monsoon + 8 spring credits)

The same caps outlined earlier in this section apply for this degree too.

The History-Economics Interdisciplinary Major Degree

This Interdisciplinary Major grounds students strongly in the two disciplines of History and Economics. It comprises a total of 80 credits (tentatively 20 courses), which are divided equally between the two departments. Consequently, students pursuing this degree are typically required to take 10 courses (each worth 4 credits) with both History and Economics departments. This section details the requirements for the 10 History courses (40 credits).

History Courses (40 credits)

1. History Matters (4 credits)
- 2 & 3. Any 2 courses from the following:
 - History of India I (4 credits)
 - History of India II (4 credits)
 - History of India III (4 credits)
 - History of India IV (4 credits)
4. Any 1 elective from the Global & Comparative History Electives basket (4 credits)
5. Any 1 elective from the Non-Indian Region-Focussed History basket (4 credits)
6. Any 1 elective from the Basic Methods Courses basket (4 credits)
7. Any 1 elective from the Advanced Methods Courses basket (4 credits)
- 8, 9, & 10. Any 3 other courses with 4 credits each. These could be History electives, third-year thesis, ISMs, or cross-listed courses (with History) from other departments (12 credits).

CAPS

- A maximum of 2 ISMs (i.e. a total of 8 credits) can count towards the History-Economics Interdisciplinary Major degree in 4 years.
- A maximum of 2 language courses (i.e. a total of 8 credits) in the same language can count towards the History-Economics Interdisciplinary Major degree in 4 years.
- A maximum of 2 courses (i.e. a total of 8 credits) offered by other departments and cross-listed with History can count towards the History-Economics Interdisciplinary Major degree in 4 years.
- Only fourth-year students can count a maximum of 2 such TA-ships (i.e. a total of 4 credits) towards their History-Economics Interdisciplinary Major.

Four-Years Degree with Research

In addition to completing 40 credits in History and another 40 credits in Economics, students pursuing the research track are required to write a thesis worth 12 research credits in History or Economics, depending on which of these two departments they want to pursue their research in.

- Fourth-Year thesis (4 monsoon + 8 spring credits)

The same caps outlined earlier in this section apply for this degree too.

History Minor

To get a Minor, students need to complete 24 credits in History. Here are the requirements:

History Courses (24 credits)

1. History Matters (4 credits)
- 2 & 3. Any 2 courses from the following:
 - History of India I (4 credits)
 - History of India II (4 credits)
 - History of India III (4 credits)
 - History of India IV (4 credits)
4. Any 1 course from the following baskets (4 credits):
 - Basic Methods Courses basket
 - Global & Comparative History Electives basket
 - Non-Indian Region-Focussed History basket
- 5 & 6. Any 2 other courses with 4 credits each. These could be History electives, third-year thesis, or ISMs (8 credits).

CAPS

- A maximum of 2 ISMs (i.e. a total of 8 credits) can count towards the History Minor degree in 4 years.
- Students cannot count language courses, TA-ship credits, or cross-listed courses (offered by other departments and cross-listed with History) towards their History Minor.

History Concentration

To get a Concentration, students need to complete 16 credits in History. Here are the requirements:

History Courses (16 credits)

1. History Matters (4 credits)
2. Any 1 course from the following:
 - History of India I (4 credits)
 - History of India II (4 credits)
 - History of India III (4 credits)
 - History of India IV (4 credits)
- 3 & 4. Any 2 other courses with 4 credits each. These could be electives, third-year thesis or an ISM. (8 credits)

CAPS

- A maximum of 1 ISM (i.e. a maximum of 4 credits) can count towards the History Concentration degree in 4 years.
- Students cannot count language courses, TA-ship credits, or cross-listed courses (offered by other departments and cross-listed with History) towards their History Concentration.

Contact Us

For further information, you can reach out to

- History representatives (historyrepresentatives@ashoka.edu.in)
- History UG Coordinator (currently Dr Pratyay Nath pratyay.nath@ashoka.edu.in)